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Which of the following most logically completes the passage?

The figures in portraits by the Spanish painter El Greco (1541–1614) are systematically elongated. In El Greco's time, the intentional distortion of human figures was unprecedented in European painting. Consequently, some critics have suggested that El Greco had an astigmatism, a type of visual impairment, that resulted in people appearing to him in the distorted way that is characteristic of his paintings. However, this suggestion cannot be the explanation, because _____.

A. several twentieth-century artists have consciously adopted from El Greco's paintings the systematic elongation of the human form

B. some people do have elongated bodies somewhat like those depicted in El Greco's portraits

C. if El Greco had an astigmatism, then, relative to how people looked to him, the elongated figures in his paintings would have appeared to him to be distorted

D. even if El Greco had an astigmatism, there would have been no correction for it available in the period in which he lived

E. there were non-European artists, even in El Greco's time, who included in their works human figures that were intentionally distorted

Argument Evaluation

Situation Figures in portraits by the Spanish painter El Greco are elongated. Some critics infer that this was because El Greco suffered from an astigmatism that made people appear elongated to him. But this explanation cannot be correct.

Reasoning *Which option would most logically complete the argument?* We need something that provides the best reason for thinking that the explanation suggested by critics—astigmatism—cannot be right. The critics' explanation might seem to work because ordinarily an artist would try to paint an image of a person so that the image would have the same proportions as the perceived person. So, if people seemed to El Greco to have longer arms and legs than they actually had, the arms and legs of the painted figures should appear to others to be longer than people's arms and legs normally are. This is how the explanation seems to make sense. But if astigmatism were the explanation, then the elongated images in his pictures should have appeared to El Greco to be too long: he would have perceived the images as longer than they actually are—and therefore as inaccurate representations of what he perceived. So, astigmatism cannot be a sufficient explanation for the elongated figures in his paintings.

A. Even if subsequent artists intentionally depicted human forms as more elongated than human figures actually are, and they did so to mimic El Greco's painted figures, that does not mean that El Greco's figures were intentionally elongated.

B. Although this option provides another possible explanation for El Greco's elongated figures, it provides no evidence that the people El Greco painted had such elongated figures.

C. **Correct**. El Greco would have perceived the images of people in his paintings as too long, relative to his perception of the people themselves. This means that even if El Greco did have astigmatism, that factor would not provide an answer to the question, "Why did El Greco paint images that he knew were distorted?"

D. The absence of an ability to correct astigmatism in El Greco's day does not undermine the hypothesis that it was astigmatism that caused El Greco to paint elongated figures.

E. Again, this suggests another possible explanation for the distortion—namely, that El Greco did it deliberately—but it does not provide any reason to think that this is the correct explanation (and that the critics' explanation is actually incorrect).

The correct answer is C.

•

Museums that house Renaissance oil paintings typically store them in environments that are carefully kept within narrow margins of temperature and humidity to inhibit any deterioration. Laboratory tests have shown that the kind of oil paint used in these paintings actually adjusts to climatic changes quite well. If, as some museum directors believe

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oil paint used in these paintings actually adjusts to climatic changes quite well. If, as some museum directors believe, **paint is the most sensitive substance in these works**, then by relaxing the standards for temperature and humidity control, **museums can reduce energy costs without risking damage to these paintings.** Museums would be rash to relax those standards, however, since results of preliminary tests indicate that gesso, a compound routinely used by Renaissance artists to help paint adhere to the canvas, is unable to withstand significant variations in humidity.

In the argument above, the two portions in **boldface** play which of the following roles?

A. The first is an objection that has been raised against the position taken by the argument; the second is the position taken by the argument.

B. The first is the position taken by the argument; the second is the position that the argument calls into question.

C. The first is a judgment that has been offered in support of the position that the argument calls into question; the second is a circumstance on which that judgment is, in part, based.

D. The first is a judgment that has been offered in support of the position that the argument calls into question; the second is that position.

E. The first is a claim that the argument calls into question; the second is the position taken by the argument.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Museums house Renaissance paintings under strictly controlled climatic conditions to prevent deterioration. This is costly. But the paint in these works actually adjusts well to climate changes. On the other hand, another compound routinely used in these paintings, gesso, does not react well to changes in humidity.

Reasoning *What roles do the two **boldfaced** statements play in the argument?* The first statement is not asserted by the author of the argument, but rather attributed as a belief to some museum directors. What the argument itself asserts is that IF this belief is true, THEN the second **boldfaced** statement is true. But the argument then goes on to offer evidence that the first statement is false and so concludes that museum directors would be ill-advised to assume that the second statement was true.

A. This option mistakenly claims that the argument adopts the second statement as its position, when in fact the argument calls this position into question.

B. Rather than adopting the first statement, the argument offers evidence that calls it into question.

C. This option contends that the first statement is a judgment that is based on the second; in fact, the opposite is true.

D. **Correct**. This option properly identifies the roles the two portions in **boldface** play in the argument.

E. While the argument does call the first statement into question, it also calls the second statement into question as well.

The correct answer is D.

•

Codex Berinensis, a Florentine copy of an ancient Roman medical treatise, is undated but contains clues to when it was produced. Its first 80 pages are by a single copyist, but the remaining 20 pages are by three different copyists, which indicates some significant disruption. Since a letter in handwriting, identified as that of the fourth copyist, mentions a plague that killed many people in Florence in 1148, Codex Berinensis was probably produced in that year.

Which of the following, if true, most strongly supports the hypothesis that Codex Berinensis was produced in 1148?

A. Other than Codex Berinensis, there are no known samples of the handwriting of the first three copyists.

B. According to the account by the fourth copyist, the plague went on for 10 months.

C. A scribe would be able to copy a page of text the size and style of Codex Berinensis in a day.

D. There was only one outbreak of plague in Florence in the 1100s.

E. The number of pages of Codex Berinensis produced by a single scribe becomes smaller with each successive change of copyist.

Argument Evaluation

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Argument Evaluation

Situation The Florentine copy of an ancient Roman work is undated but provides clues as to the time it was produced. The first 80 pages of Codex Berinensis are the work of one copyist. The fact that the last 20 pages are the work of a succession of three different copyists is an indication of serious turmoil at the time the copying was done. Since a letter in the fourth copyist's handwriting reveals that a plague killed many people there in 1148, Codex Berinensis was probably produced in that year.

Reasoning *Which information supports the hypothesis dating the Codex to 1148?* Consider the basis of the hypothesis: the succession of copyists indicating the work was significantly disrupted, and the fourth copyist's letter indicating the plague of 1148 caused serious loss of life. From this, it is argued that the plague of 1148 was the reason for the multiple copyists and that the work can thus be dated to that year. What if there were multiple plagues?

In that case, Codex Berinensis could have been produced at another time. If, instead, only one plague occurred in the 1100s, the elimination of that possibility supports the hypothesis that the work was done in 1148.

A. Examples of the copyists' handwriting might help date Codex Berinensis; the absence of handwriting samples does not help support 1148 as the date.

B. The length of the plague, while it may account for the succession of copyists, does not help support the particular year the work was done.

C. The amount of work a copyist could achieve each day does not provide any information about the year the work appeared.

D. **Correct.** This statement properly identifies a circumstance that supports the hypothesis.

E. The productivity or tenure of the various copyists is irrelevant to establishing the date.

The correct answer is D.

•

Excavations of the Roman city of Sepphoris have uncovered numerous detailed mosaics depicting several readily identifiable animal species: a hare, a partridge, and various Mediterranean fish. Oddly, most of the species represented did not live in the Sepphoris region when these mosaics were created. Since identical motifs appear in mosaics found in other Roman cities, however, the mosaics of Sepphoris were very likely created by traveling artisans from some other part of the Roman Empire.

Which of the following is an assumption on which the argument depends?

A. The Sepphoris mosaics are not composed exclusively of types of stones found naturally in the Sepphoris area.

B. There is no single region to which all the species depicted in the Sepphoris mosaics are native.

C. No motifs appear in the Sepphoris mosaics that do not also appear in the mosaics of some other Roman city.

D. All of the animal figures in the Sepphoris mosaics are readily identifiable as representations of known species.

E. There was not a common repertory of mosaic designs with which artisans who lived in various parts of the Roman Empire were familiar.

Argument Construction

Situation Mosaics uncovered at the site of the Roman city of Sepphoris depict animals that did not live in Sepphoris. Because identical motifs appear in other Roman cities, traveling artisans from elsewhere in the Roman Empire likely created the mosaics of Sepphoris.

Reasoning *What assumption underlies this argument?* The argument implicitly assumes that the artisans who created the mosaics had seen the animals depicted firsthand. This suggests that the artisans had been to the regions where these animals live and then traveled to Sepphoris to create the mosaics depicting non-native animals. This, in turn, suggests the assumption that the artisans were not including these motifs based solely on familiarity with motifs common throughout the Empire.

A. The argument draws its conclusion based on subjects of the mosaics, not on the types of stones used in the

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A. The argument draws its conclusion based on subjects of the mosaics, not on the types of stones used in the mosaics, so the origin of the stone is irrelevant.

B. The argument does not rely on the assumption that the species depicted in the Sepphoris mosaics are native to disparate regions, only on the idea that traveling artisans must have seen such species.

C. Nothing in the argument relies on whether or not any of the motifs appear exclusively in Sepphoris. The argument relies only on the fact that there are motifs depicting animals not native to Sepphoris.

D. The argument requires only that at least some of the animals in the mosaics are identifiable as known species that are non-native to Sepphoris.

E. **Correct.** If there was a common repertory of mosaic designs with which artisans who lived in various parts of the Roman Empire were familiar, then it could well be that artisans native to Sepphoris would have been familiar with these designs and could have produced them without ever having seen for themselves animals of the species depicted and without having been the same artisans who created the mosaics elsewhere. Therefore, the argument must assume that such a common repertory did not exist.

The correct answer is E.

•

As a large corporation in a small country, Hachnut wants its managers to have international experience, so **each year it sponsors management education abroad for its management trainees.** Hachnut has found, however, that the attrition rate of graduates from this program is very high, with many of them leaving Hachnut to join competing firms soon after completing the program. Hachnut does use performance during the program as a criterion in deciding among candidates for management positions, but **both this function and the goal of providing international experience could be achieved in other ways.** Therefore, if the attrition problem cannot be successfully addressed, Hachnut should discontinue the sponsorship program.

In the argument given, the two **boldfaced** portions play which of the following roles?

A. The first describes a practice that the argument seeks to justify; the second states a judgment that is used in support of a justification for that practice.

B. The first describes a practice that the argument seeks to explain; the second presents part of the argument's explanation of that practice.

C. The first introduces a practice that the argument seeks to evaluate; the second provides grounds for holding that the practice cannot achieve its objective.

D. The first introduces a policy that the argument seeks to evaluate; the second provides grounds for holding that the policy is not needed.

E. The first introduces a consideration supporting a policy that the argument seeks to evaluate; the second provides evidence for concluding that the policy should be abandoned.

Argument Construction

Situation One of Hachnut's goals is for its managers to have international experience, so it sponsors education abroad for management trainees. Graduates of this program, however, frequently leave the company soon after the training to work for competitors. Even though Hachnut uses trainees' performance in the program to make placement decisions, it should discontinue the sponsorship program, because both achievement of international experience and assistance in making placement decisions can be achieved in other ways.

Reasoning *What role do the two portions in **boldface** play in the argument?* The first **boldfaced** portion introduces the policy of sponsorship of management training abroad. The argument goes on to evaluate this policy in light of the second **boldfaced** portion—which states that there are alternative ways of accomplishing what the sponsorship is intended to do—and concludes that the program should be discontinued.

A. The argument does not seek to justify the practice described in the first **boldfaced** portion, and the second portion argues against the practice, not for it.

B. The argument does not seek to explain the practice, but rather to evaluate whether it should be retained.

C. Although the first **boldfaced** portion does introduce a practice that the argument seeks to evaluate, the second

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C. Although the first **boldfaced** portion does introduce a practice that the argument seeks to evaluate, the second does not provide grounds for holding that the practice cannot achieve its objective, but rather states that there are other means of achieving that objective.

D. **Correct.** The first **boldfaced** portion introduces a policy the argument seeks to evaluate. The second states that there are alternative ways to achieve the goal, which provides grounds for holding that the policy is not needed.

E. Although the second **boldfaced** portion does provide a reason to abandon the policy the argument evaluates, the first does not introduce a consideration supporting that policy, but rather introduces the policy itself.

The correct answer is D.

•

Letter to the editor: If the water level in the Searle River Delta continues to drop, the rising sea level will make the water saltier and less suitable for drinking. Currently, 40 percent of the water from upstream tributaries is diverted to neighboring areas. To keep the delta's water level from dropping any further, we should end all current diversions from the upstream tributaries. Neighboring water utilities are likely to see higher costs and diminished water supplies, but these costs are necessary to preserve the delta.

Which of the following would, if true, indicate a serious potential weakness of the suggested plan of action?

A. Desalination equipment would allow water from the delta to be used for drinking even it if became saltier.

B. Water level is only one factor that affects salinity in the delta.

C. The upstream tributaries' water levels are controlled by systems of dams and reservoirs.

D. Neighboring areas have grown in population since the water was first diverted from upstream tributaries.

E. Much of the recent drop in the delta's water level can be attributed to a prolonged drought that has recently ended.

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation A letter states that progressively lower levels in the Searle River Delta will raise the salt content of its water and make that water less fit for human consumption. Because 40 percent of the water flowing to the delta from upstream is diverted for the use of upstream communities, the letter proposes reclaiming that diverted water regardless of negative impacts on upstream communities in order to protect the delta's water levels from dropping further.

Reasoning *What would weaken the argument for this plan?* The argument for the plan to end diversion of water rests on the assumption that if diversion continues, water levels in the Searle River Delta will likewise continue to drop. If some additional factor suggested water levels in the delta might hold steady or rebound *even if* upstream communities continue to divert water, then that new fact would weaken the argument that the plan is necessary to protect the delta.

A. The fact that desalination equipment could create drinking water would argue against the necessity of the plan *specifically* for providing drinking water, but it would not weaken the argument that the plan is necessary to protect the delta's water levels per se.

B. Even if factors other than water level affect the delta's salinity, that would not weaken the argument that the plan is necessary to defend the delta's water levels.

C. A system of dams upstream would not affect the argument that upstream communities should no longer be allowed to divert water because that water is needed in the Searle River Delta.

D. Growing need for water upstream would increase the negative impact of the plan, but it would not undermine the claim that the plan is necessary to protect the delta.

E. **Correct.** If the drop in the delta's water level was largely caused by a drought, and if that drought has ended, then the water level in the delta might stay constant or rise even without the plan to end water diversion by upstream communities. Water flowing into the delta from increased rain would weaken the argument that the plan is necessary to defend the delta.

The correct answer is E.

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